Interpersonal synchrony

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The hidden costs of being in sync

As a clinical psychologist who studies therapeutic processes, I tend to view nonverbal synchrony, the automatic coordination of behaviour and physiology between individuals during social interaction (for example, movement, posture, facial expressions or vocal rhythm), as a positive aspect of relationships. In psychotherapy, moving with a patient, subtly mirroring posture or rhythm, and 'being with' them in a felt, nonverbal way is an embodied marker of attunement. However, a paper by Galbusera and colleagues fundamentally complicates that intuition.

In their study, participants engaged in a wordless, improvised dyadic movement interaction while whole-body motion capture quantified both interpersonal synchrony (coordination between partners) and intrapersonal synchrony (coordination within a person's own body). Participants also completed a brief self-report questionnaire that assessed momentary changes in mood and self-regulatory capacity.

The results pointed toward a potential trade-off. Greater interpersonal synchrony predicted higher post-task positive affect, replicating a robust literature on synchrony as 'social glue'. However, greater interpersonal synchrony also predicted greater difficulty in affect modulation. In other words, participants who experienced greater interpersonal synchrony were more likely to feel overwhelmed or less in control of their emotions. By contrast, intrapersonal synchrony was associated with better affect regulation but dampened positive affect. Together, these findings suggest that feeling good and being regulated are sometimes opposite goals: although interpersonal synchrony reliably boosts positive affect, it also encourages an 'outsourcing' of regulatory effort to the dyad, whereas the autonomous self-organization (intrapersonal synchrony) required to effectively modulate one's own emotions comes at the expense of positive mood.

On the basis of these results and drawing on an enactive approach to cognitive science, Galbusera and colleagues argue that psychological stability depends on a balance between social attunement and autonomy. The self is neither a sealed-off entity nor fully dissolved in interaction. Too much synchrony risks tipping this balance.

For psychotherapy, this understanding raises important questions. If close coordination enhances positive affect while dampening self-regulatory capacity, then a therapeutic stance that consistently prioritizes attunement might come at the cost of undermining regulation. Perhaps there are phases of therapy during which high synchrony is adaptive (such as when safety and connection are paramount) and others when subtle desynchronization is necessary to support autonomy and regulation. This understanding also resonates with the concept of empathic failure in psychodynamic theory, which refers to the therapist's inevitable misattunements; when adequately repaired and not excessive, these can support the development of a more cohesive, autonomous self.

The implications of the study by Galbusera and colleagues extend to other relationships beyond psychotherapy, such as parent–child interactions and romantic partnerships. Although excessive attunement (for example, finishing each other's sentences) is often idealized as closeness, it might inadvertently promote dependency or emotional outsourcing. From this perspective, healthy relationships might be defined by flexible oscillation between connection and separation rather than by constant synchrony. Future studies could test whether positive outcomes depend less on the absolute level of attunement and more on the ability to flexibly shift between moments of connection and separation.

> **"healthy relationships might be defined by flexible oscillation between connection and separation rather than by constant synchrony"**

Overall, the study by Galbusera et al. challenges the field to move beyond simple 'more is better' assumptions about synchrony. It invites a more nuanced, process-oriented view of interpersonal regulation.

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Competing interests

The author declares no competing interests.

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